one of the highest rates of stunting. In terms of average height, Indian men ranked 180th out of 200 countries and Indian women ranked 182nd out of 200 (Chinese men and women ranked 65th and 54th in the world, respectively, and were the tallest in Asia).[20] More importantly, I mentioned that India had one of the highest rates of stunting in the world and the largest absolute number of stunted individuals. Several officers shrugged, annoyed at my 'negative comment on India', and insisted that height did not matter. After all, as one officer huffily put it, Napoleon was short, as was Nehru. The point though is that stunting is not so much about height; what matters are the cognitive implications of stunting, namely, the impairment of normal development. Moreover, there is evidence that the mental effects cannot be reversed if malnutrition persists after age two to five. If so, India will have tens of millions of adults, perhaps as many as 400 million, who did not recover from early childhood stunting and will live a life with impaired cognition. This would mean several hundred million people with low numeracy–literacy and deficient problem-solving skills, with its consequences for workplace productivity, especially in a modern industrial and service economy. If so, India's demographic dividend could turn into a demographic nightmare.

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Any Indian who has travelled in China will have experienced the greater productivity – or efficiency – of Chinese workers and will undoubtedly have their favourite rueful story. My story is from 1998, when I was in Shanghai for a conference. One afternoon after lunch, the Indian Sinologist Giri Deshingkar and I ventured out to encash our travellers' cheques. Walking along, we marvelled at the gleaming skyscrapers and clean streets around us, at the orderly hustle and bustle of the city, as we sought out a bank. At the bank, Deshingkar said to me in the tone of Sherlock Holmes to Watson: 'Just observe.' I observed that the bank had only one employee present at the time. I also observed several other foreign and Chinese customers in line and urged Deshingkar to leave our transactions to another